Environment Setup

SQL Server, SSMS and the course databases, on Windows and Mac

The guide follows the Environment Setup lesson. It adds what the lesson could not show: the newer screens, the other ways to run SQL Server, and the fixes for the common errors.

1 Choose your setup

Path	For	Same screens as the videos	Cost
SQL Server Express + SSMS, section 3	Windows	yes	free
Docker, section 5	Mac	the same SQL, in Visual Studio Code	free
Parallels with Windows, section 6	Mac	yes, SSMS inside Windows	about 100 dollars a year, 14-day trial

Read only your path. Windows: sections 3 and 4. Mac: section 5, or section 6 for Windows inside the Mac. Everyone: section 10 when something breaks.

My advice: on Windows, take the first path, it is the one in the videos. On a Mac, take Docker: free, light, and the SQL is the same. Take Parallels if you want SSMS exactly as in the videos and your Mac has 16 GB of memory.

2 What you get in the materials

Download the course materials once. You get this folder:

```
sql-ultimate-course/
├── 00_setup/           this guide, and the one-click Docker setup for Mac
├── 01_datasets/
│   ├── 00_sql-server/  init-sqlserver-mydatabase.sql, init-sqlserver-salesdb.sql,
│   │                   MyDatabase.bak, SalesDB.bak
│   ├── 01_mysql/       the same two databases for MySQL
│   ├── 02_postgres/    the same two databases for PostgreSQL
│   └── 03_csv-files/   the five SalesDB tables as CSV files
├── 02_docs/            the slides of every chapter as PDF
└── 03_scripts/         every query from the course, one file per chapter
```

The course uses two databases:

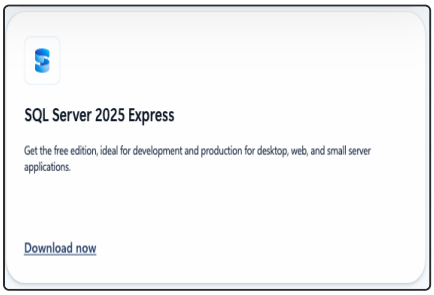
Database	Used in
`MyDatabase`	SELECT, DDL, DML, Filtering Data, Joins, String Functions, Aggregate Functions
`SalesDB`	everything else, from Set Operators to AI and SQL

Every script in `03_scripts/` starts with a `USE` line, so it tells you which database it needs.

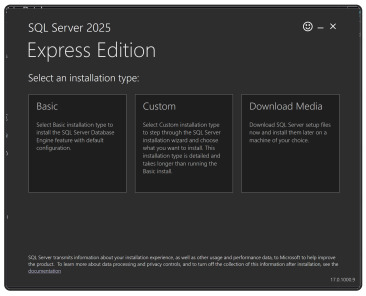
3 Windows: install SQL Server and SSMS

SQL Server Express is the free edition, and it is all you need. The videos show SQL Server 2022. The download page now offers 2025, and it works the same.

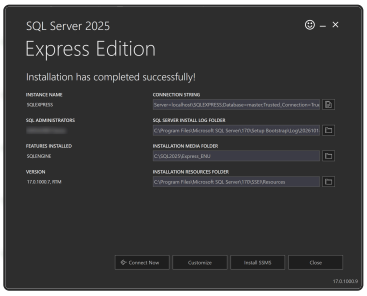
- Open the SQL Server downloads page, scroll to the **Express** card, and click **Download now**.
- Run the downloaded file and choose **Basic**. Accept the licence and click **Install**.
- The last screen shows your server name: `localhost\SQLEXPRESS` . Keep it, you need it in a minute. Your Windows account is now the administrator of this SQL Server.
- Download SQL Server Management Studio (SSMS) and install it with the default options. The installer may offer extra components. You need none of them.



Step 1: the Express card.



Step 2: choose Basic.

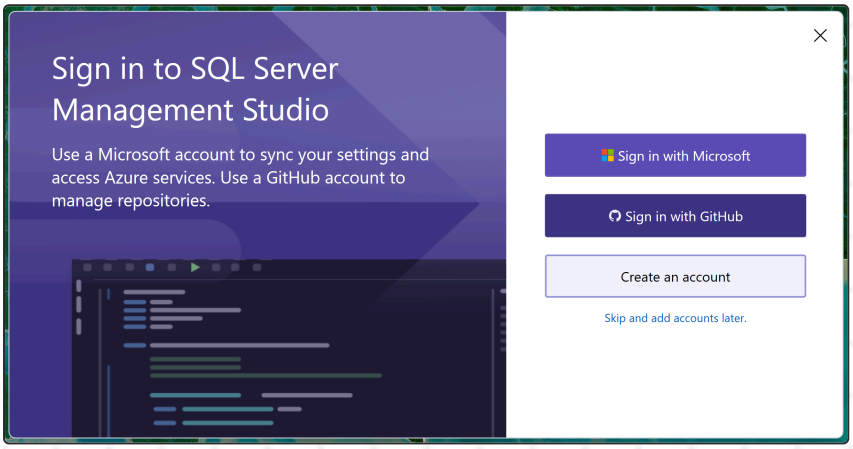


Step 3: the server name.

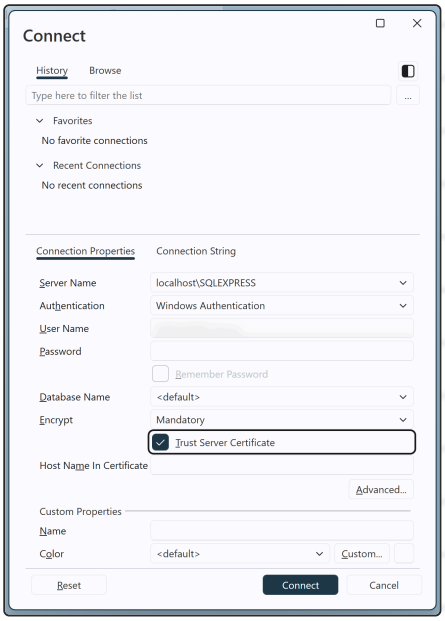
Connect for the first time

SSMS 21 and newer look different from the videos.

- At the first start, SSMS asks you to sign in. You do not need an account: click **Skip and add accounts later** under the buttons.
- In the **Connect** window, type the server name `localhost\SQLEXPRESS`. If the field is empty, that is normal.
- Authentication: **Windows Authentication**.
- Tick **Trust Server Certificate**. Without it you get a certificate error.
- Click **Connect**. Your server appears on the left, in the Object Explorer.



Step 1: the skip link under the buttons.



Steps 2 to 4: the Connect window, filled in.

4 Create the databases

The lesson shows three ways. The first one is the easiest and works on every version.

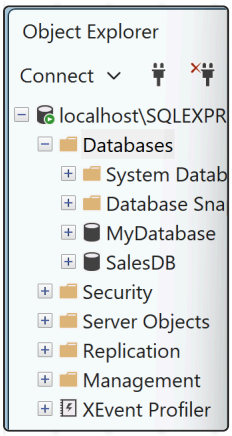
Way 1: run the scripts

- In SSMS, click **File > Open > File** and open `01_datasets/00_sql-server/init-sqlserver-mydatabase.sql`.
- Click **Execute**, or press F5. Refresh the Databases folder: `MyDatabase` is there.
- Do the same with `init-sqlserver-salesdb.sql`. Before you run it, make sure the database dropdown in the toolbar says `master`.

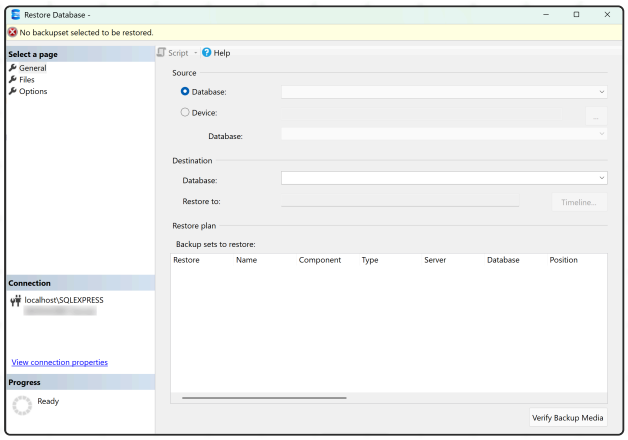
Use only the scripts in `00_sql-server/`. The scripts in `01_mysql/` and `02_postgres/` are for other engines, and SSMS cannot run them.

Way 2: restore the backups

- Copy `MyDatabase.bak` and `SalesDB.bak` into the Backup folder of your SQL Server: `C:\Program Files\Microsoft SQL Server\MSSQL17.SQLEXPRESS\MSSQL\Backup` for SQL Server 2025, `MSSQL16` for 2022. SQL Server cannot read your Downloads folder, so this copy matters.
- In the Object Explorer, right-click **Databases > Restore Database**.
- Choose **Device**, click the three dots, click **Add**, pick the backup file, and click **OK** twice.



Way 1 done.



Way 2: Device, the three dots, Add.

> One rule to know: a backup restores on the same SQL Server version or a newer one, never on an older one. The course backups come from SQL Server 2022. On SQL Server 2019 or older, use way 1.

Way 3: import the CSV files

Right-click a database, then **Tasks > Import Flat File**, and pick a CSV file. The lesson shows this as a demo. For the course, use way 1 or way 2. A CSV file cannot tell an empty text from NULL, and the NULL lessons need that difference.

5 Mac: Docker

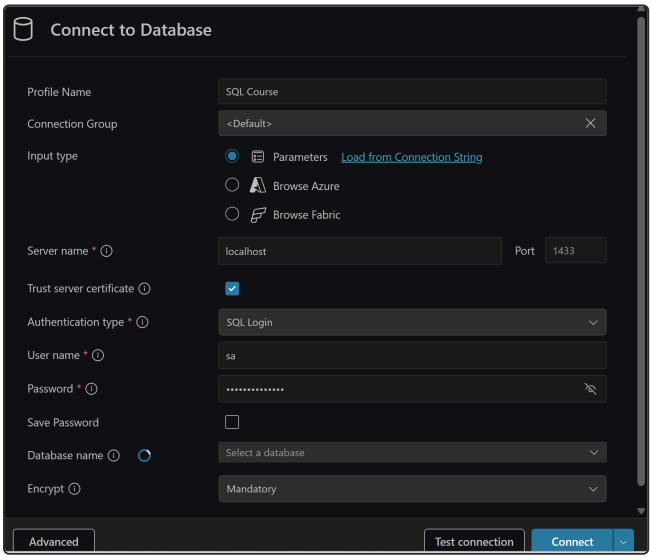
SQL Server does not install on macOS, and SSMS is Windows only. With Docker, SQL Server runs in a small container on your Mac, and you write your queries in Visual Studio Code. The SQL is the same.

Install, once

- Install Docker Desktop, the Apple chip version. Start it and leave it running.
- Docker Desktop settings, **General**. Set the Virtual Machine Manager to **Apple Virtualization framework** and turn on **Use Rosetta for x86_64/amd64 emulation on Apple Silicon**. SQL Server ships for Intel chips only, and this setting lets your Mac run it.
- Install Visual Studio Code and, inside it, the extension SQL Server (mssql) by Microsoft. It is Microsoft's tool for the Mac.

Start the course databases: one click

- In the course materials, open `00_setup/mac-docker` and double-click `start.command`.
- Wait a minute. The first start downloads SQL Server and creates `MyDatabase` and `SalesDB` from the course scripts. Later, double-click the same file again, or start the container `sql-course` in Docker Desktop.
- In Visual Studio Code, open the SQL Server extension on the left and add a connection. Server name `localhost`, port `1433`, tick **Trust server certificate**, authentication **SQL Login**, user `sa`, password `SqlServer!2026`.
- Open a script from `03_scripts/`, run it against the connection, and you are in the course.



Step 3: the connection form, filled in.

The same by hand

If you prefer one command of your own, this starts an empty SQL Server 2022. Choose your own password: at least 8 characters with upper case, lower case, a number and a symbol.

```
docker run -e "ACCEPT_EULA=Y" -e "MSSQL_SA_PASSWORD=YourStrong!Passw0rd" \
  -p 1433:1433 --name sql --platform linux/amd64 \
  -d mcr.microsoft.com/mssql/server:2022-latest
```

Then connect as above and run `init-sqlserver-mydatabase.sql` and `init-sqlserver-salesdb.sql` from Visual Studio Code. Microsoft's own guide for this: SQL Server in a Docker container.

6 Windows inside your Mac: Parallels

This path gives you SSMS exactly as in the videos, because you run Windows on your Mac.

- Install Parallels Desktop. It downloads and installs Windows 11 for you in a few clicks. It costs about 100 dollars a year, with a 14-day free trial, and Windows needs its own licence.
- Give the virtual machine at least 6 GB of memory. A Mac with 16 GB is the comfortable minimum.
- Inside Windows, follow sections 3 and 4 like any Windows user.

SQL Server Express installs and runs on the ARM version of Windows 11, even though Microsoft does not list it as supported. Tested with SQL Server 2025 Express and SSMS 22 in Parallels on an Apple chip.

7 MySQL and PostgreSQL

The course is recorded on SQL Server, and that is the engine I recommend: every query in the videos runs as shown. If you still want MySQL or PostgreSQL, here is what to install, how to load the two databases, and the differences you will meet.

Install and load

MySQL

- Install MySQL Community Server and MySQL Workbench. On Windows, the MySQL Installer brings both.
- In Workbench: **File > Open SQL Script**, open `01_datasets/01_mysql/init-mysql-mydatabase.sql`, and run it with the lightning icon.
- The same with `init-mysql-salesdb.sql`.

PostgreSQL

- Install PostgreSQL with the EDB installer, which brings pgAdmin. On a Mac, Postgres.app is the lighter choice, with pgAdmin or DBeaver as the query tool.
- Open `01_datasets/02_postgres/init-postgres-mydatabase.sql` in the query tool while connected to the `postgres` database, and run the lines up to `CREATE DATABASE`.
- Connect to the new database and run the rest. The same with `init-postgres-salesdb.sql`.

Both engines keep the table names in lower case: `customers`, `orders`, `orders_archive` in MySQL, and `sales.customers` in PostgreSQL.

What is different

Most of the course runs unchanged: SELECT, filtering, joins, set operators, CASE, aggregations, window functions, subqueries, CTEs, views. These are the parts that differ, and how to write them on the other engines.

In the course (SQL Server)	MySQL	PostgreSQL
`SELECT TOP 3 * FROM t`	`SELECT * FROM t LIMIT 3`	`SELECT * FROM t LIMIT 3`
`GETDATE()`	`NOW()`	`NOW()`
`DATETRUNC(month, d)`	`DATE_FORMAT(d, '%Y-%m-01')`	`DATE_TRUNC('month', d)`
`DATENAME(month, d)`	`MONTHNAME(d)`	`TO_CHAR(d, 'Month')`
`DATEPART(year, d)`, `YEAR(d)`	`YEAR(d)`	`EXTRACT(YEAR FROM d)`
`EOMONTH(d)`	`LAST_DAY(d)`	`(DATE_TRUNC('month', d) + INTERVAL '1 month - 1 day')::date`
`DATEADD(day, 7, d)`	`DATE_ADD(d, INTERVAL 7 DAY)`	`d + INTERVAL '7 days'`
`DATEDIFF(day, a, b)`	`DATEDIFF(b, a)`, days only	`b - a` for dates
`FORMAT(d, 'yyyy-MM-dd')`	`DATE_FORMAT(d, '%Y-%m-%d')`	`TO_CHAR(d, 'YYYY-MM-DD')`
`CONVERT(DATE, x)`	`CAST(x AS DATE)`	`CAST(x AS DATE)` or `x::date`
`ISNULL(a, b)`	`IFNULL(a, b)` or `COALESCE(a, b)`	`COALESCE(a, b)`

In the course (SQL Server)	MySQL	PostgreSQL
`IIF(cond, a, b)`	`IF(cond, a, b)`	`CASE WHEN cond THEN a ELSE b END`
`LEN(s)`	`CHAR_LENGTH(s)`	`LENGTH(s)`
`CHARINDEX(x, s)`	`LOCATE(x, s)`	`POSITION(x IN s)`
`'a' + 'b'` for text	`CONCAT('a', 'b')`	`'a' || 'b'`
`[Column Name]`	`` `Column Name` ``	`"Column Name"`
`Sales.Customers`	`customers`, MySQL has no schemas inside a database	`sales.customers`
`#temp` tables	`CREATE TEMPORARY TABLE`	`CREATE TEMP TABLE`
`SELECT ... INTO new_table`	`CREATE TABLE new_table AS SELECT ...`	`CREATE TABLE new_table AS SELECT ...`
`BULK INSERT`	`LOAD DATA INFILE`	`COPY ... FROM`

The chapters on stored procedures, triggers, indexes, partitions, execution plans and performance tips are SQL Server chapters. The ideas carry over, the syntax does not. When a query from those chapters fails on another engine, that is the reason, not a mistake in your setup.

8 The projects

The data warehouse project and the data analytics project come as their own packages. Each one has a `00_setup` folder with its own guide and its own one-click Docker start, so open that guide when you get there. On a Mac, the packages share one SQL Server: the second one-click finds the running container and uses it.

9 AdventureWorks

The index chapter uses Microsoft's sample database `AdventureWorksDW2022`. It is not part of the course materials, so get it from Microsoft:

- Open the AdventureWorks sample databases page at Microsoft Learn.
- Download `AdventureWorksDW2022.bak`, the data warehouse with `FactInternetSales`. `AdventureWorks2022.bak` is the other, operational database, and it does not have that table.
- Restore it like the course backups, section 4, way 2.

The 2022 files need SQL Server 2022 or newer. On SQL Server 2019, take the 2019 files from the same page: the data is the same.

10 When something breaks

Find your message in the first column. The fix is in the last one.

Install and connect

What you see	Why	What to do
SSMS asks you to sign in at the first start	optional account	Click **Skip and add accounts later**
The server name field is empty	normal	Type `localhost\SQLEXPRESS`
Error 26, "Error Locating Server/Instance Specified"	SQL Server is not running, or the name is wrong	Open **Services**, start "SQL Server (SQLEXPRESS)". If you installed the Developer edition, the name is `localhost` without the instance
"The certificate chain was issued by an authority that is not trusted"	SSMS encrypts the connection	Tick **Trust Server Certificate**
Installer: "Wait on the Database Engine recovery handle failed"	SQL Server could not start during setup	Uninstall SQL Server, restart Windows, install again. If it fails again, the real reason is in the ERRORLOG file under `C:\Program Files\Microsoft SQL Server\MSSQL17.SQLEXPRESS\MSSQL\Log`
SQL Server 2025 setup stops at the rules check	installer problem on some machines	Install SQL Server 2022 Express instead. Everything here runs on it
Your laptop does not let you install anything	no administrator rights	SQL Server needs them. Ask IT, or use a personal computer

Databases and files

What you see	Why	What to do
Msg 262, "CREATE DATABASE permission denied in database 'master'"	your Windows login is not an administrator of this SQL Server. Someone else installed it, often IT	Log in with the Windows account that installed SQL Server, or ask an administrator to add your login to the **sysadmin** role (Security > Logins > Properties > Server Roles)
Msg 911, "Database 'MyDatabase' does not exist", or many syntax errors with backticks	you ran the MySQL or PostgreSQL script in SSMS	Use the scripts in `01_datasets/00_sql-server/`
The restore window does not show the .bak file, or "Access is denied"	SQL Server cannot read Downloads	Copy the file into the Backup folder, section 4, way 2
Msg 3169, the backup "is incompatible with this server"	your SQL Server is older than 2022	Run the scripts, way 1, or install SQL Server 2022 or 2025 Express
"'DATETRUNC' is not a recognized built-in function name"	SQL Server older than 2022	Install SQL Server 2022 or newer. The course uses functions from 2022
A .sql file opens in Notepad, or the .bak shows as text in the browser	the file is not linked to SSMS	Open SSMS first, then **File > Open > File**. For downloads, right-click the link and choose **Save link as**

Docker

What you see	Why	What to do
"Cannot connect to the Docker daemon"	Docker Desktop is not running	Start Docker Desktop, wait for the whale icon, try again
"no matching manifest for linux/arm64"	the Intel image needs emulation	Turn on Rosetta in Docker Desktop, section 5. By hand, add `--platform linux/amd64` to the command
"port is already allocated"	another SQL Server listens on 1433, not one of these packages	Stop it, or change the first `1433` in `docker-compose.yml` to `1434` and connect to port `1434`
The container stops right after the start	the password breaks the rules	At least 8 characters with upper case, lower case, a number and a symbol
"SQL Server did not answer" from start.command	SQL Server could not start, most often Rosetta is off	Docker Desktop settings, **General**, turn on Rosetta, section 5. The container's log in Docker Desktop names the reason

If you are still stuck, write in the Q&A with the exact error message and a screenshot of the window. Then I can see what happened.